

Reptiles

Many reptiles live in grasslands where they can tolerate the harsh conditions during the dry season. However, when the grass is short it provides little cover in which to hide, so reptiles need to be camouflaged. Many grassland snakes and lizards are dull coloured, with brown or grey mottled markings that blend into the surroundings.

Grass snake

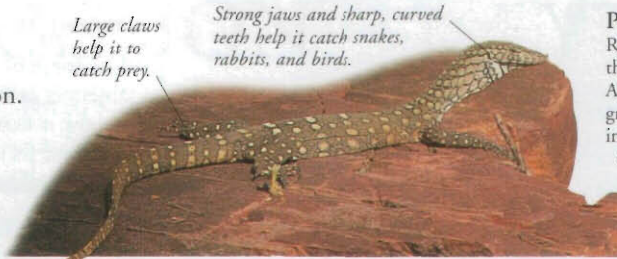
This small, non-venomous reptile lives in grasslands close to water. It is a strong swimmer, and catches much of its prey, such as fish, frogs, and newts, in water. If attacked, it releases a bad smell, or feigns death by lying on its back, with its tongue hanging out. Grass snakes hibernate in winter, usually in holes in the ground.

Grass snakes usually lay a clutch of up to 30–40 eggs in decaying vegetation.



Large claws help it to catch prey.

Strong jaws and sharp, curved teeth help it catch snakes, rabbits, and birds.



The perentie can lash its huge tail from side-to-side in self-defence.

Perentie

Reaching a length of 2 m (7 ft), the perentie is the largest of the Australian monitor lizards. It lives in grasslands and among rocky outcrops in deserts. Like other monitors, the perentie is a carnivore with a voracious appetite. It also eats carrion. If threatened, it inflates its body, hisses, and lashes out with its tail.

Puff adder

Hidden within the grass stems of the African savannah lurks the slow-moving, dangerous puff adder. Camouflaged in the grass, it lies in wait for prey. It produces a powerful venom for immobilizing prey, such as rodents and frogs, and as a means of defence, against mongooses, secretary birds, and eagles.

Mottled markings break up outline against the grass.



Birds

Grasslands support many birds, among them bustards, guineafowl, francolins, long-legged seriemas, and the secretary bird. Many birds nest on the ground as there are few trees. The burrowing owl even goes underground and nests in burrows on the American prairies. Other birds, such as weaver birds, flock in droves to the same isolated tree to weave their basket-shaped nests.

Emu

The emu is the second largest bird in the world, after the ostrich. It is flightless and lives on the Australian grasslands, where it feeds on grasses, berries, fruit, and insects. Emus live in small, nomadic flocks, moving long distances in search of food and water. They are powerful runners, covering the ground in 2.7 m (9 ft) strides, reaching speeds of up to 50 kmh (30 mph) over short distances. Males incubate the eggs and look after the chicks.

Long, shaggy feathers

Long neck gives bustard a clear view over the grass.



Indian white-backed vulture

Vultures are a group of carrion-eating birds of prey. They perform a vital role of scavenging and keeping the environment clean by disposing of waste. Indian white-backed vultures hunt, by soaring on thermal currents from where they can spot a kill; once sighted, the vultures land to feed on the remains. The sight of vultures spiralling down draws other scavengers to the kill.

Bare skin on neck

Long legs for running

Vulture feeding on a goat



Plants

Grasslands sustain numerous types of grass, among the best known are red oat grass in Africa and buffalo grass in America. Which species grow depends on altitude, temperature, soil type, and rainfall. Grassland trees often have deep roots to reach water supplies far below the ground, allowing them to survive during the dry season. Some trees can store water. The baobab tree can store about 9,000 l (2,400 gal) of water in its huge swollen trunk.

Acacia tree

The characteristic tree of Africa's arid and semi-arid grasslands is the flat-topped umbrella tree, *Acacia tortilis*. This tree is protected from grazing animals by sharp thorns, but these do not deter giraffes, which manage to pluck the leaves and blossoms. Acacias produce a mass of pods that fall to the ground providing food for many animals. Acacias also provide welcome shade for the animals of the savannah.

Fluffy, white seed heads



Pampas grass

The Argentine pampas extends from the foothills of the Andes to the Atlantic coast. Many of the grasses that grow there can be up to 2.5 m (8 ft) high.

Petals and bracts are covered with small hairs.



Anemones

When the snow retreats on the Asian steppes, many wild flowers, including anemones and peonies, grow amidst the sea of grass.

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